majority also believes that Modi's economic policies favour big business to the detriment of other sections.

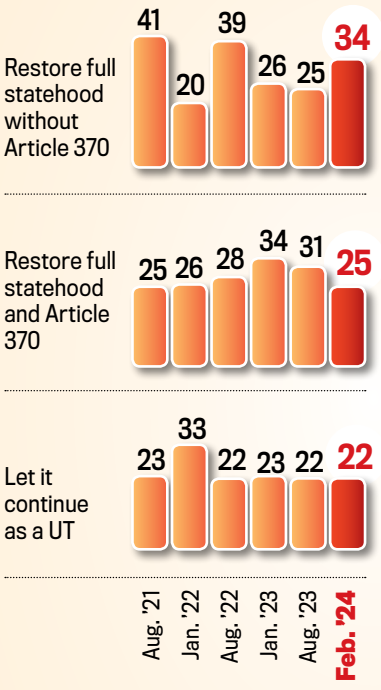
WHY THE DICHOTOMY

Any other government with such dismal views about its economic performance would have seen its poll numbers plummeting. Not Modi and the NDA, who exhibit no sign of anti-incumbency in MOTN numbers. What explains this dichotomy in responses, especially on economic issues? The enormous trust that the electorate resposes in Modi. He is seen not just as a decisive leader but also as someone who works tirelessly for the public good and against whom no major corruption charges have stuck. Voters do not pin the blame for their economic woes on Modi; instead they applaud his ability to steer the economy back on the path of high growth in the face of a devastating global pandemic. They also appreciate his successful conduct of the G20 summit, which saw India project itself as a *vishwa mitra* (friend of the world). In fact, this MOTN shows raising India's global stature as the second most important thing Modi will be remembered for after his contribution to the building of the Ram mandir. The abrogation of Article 370 comes third. Delivering these two major items on the saffron agenda has ensured the BJP not only retains its core voter base but may also convince the Hindu fence-sitters.

With the MOTN showing a third successive humiliating defeat for the Congress in the general election, the party needs to do a serious reality check. Along with losing the goodwill of I.N.D.I.A. allies, it has also forfeited a golden opportunity to mount a formidable opposition against Modi and the BJP. Having won Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka, the Congress should have ideally marshalled all resources to extend the winning streak to at least one of the three Hindi heartland states—MP, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—that went to the polls in November 2023, as it did in Telangana. Both inflation and unemployment offered potent electoral ammunition against the ruling dispensation. Instead, the Opposition parties, particularly the Congress, failed to demonstrate the leadership qualities needed to paper over differences and craft a powerful counter-narrative to challenge Modi and the BJP.

The reason why the electorate does not attribute their economic woes to Modi is because of the enormous trust they bestow on him

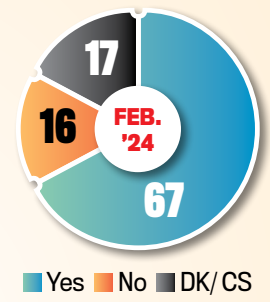
Q. What should the Union government do to restore 'normalcy' in Jammu & Kashmir?



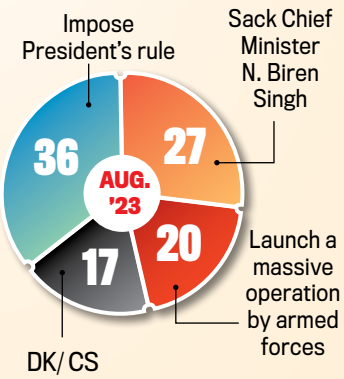
Rest, DK/ CS

For a fully functional J&K, 34 per cent respondents support restoration of statehood, but not Article 370. A significant quarter, though, supports restoration of Art. 370 too

Q. Do you think assembly elections should be held in Kashmir this year?



Q. In view of the intermittent violence going on in Manipur for nine months, what should the government do to restore peace in the state?



All figures in % and rounded off